Gathering Documents

Like any employee or contractor with top-secret NSA clearance and use of an NSA computer, Snowden had access to critical NSA files. These files included documents detailing NSA surveillance programs. As the top technologist in Dell's Hawaii office, Snowden's access went even further—he had access to everything. Though Snowden has not explained how he gathered documents, experts in the US Intelligence Community assume he used a web crawler—a computer program that searches for, and then copies, files that contain certain keywords. He then saved those document files to portable flash drives.

One area Snowden could not access while at Dell was information about the NSA's global cyberwarfare activity. It so happened that another NSA contractor, Booz Allen Hamilton, had an office nearby that could provide him with that data. In March 2013, Snowden applied for, and landed, a job as a computer infrastructure analyst at the company. While at Booz Allen Hamilton, Snowden was able to confirm the NSA was intercepting and storing vast amounts of US communications without warrants or suspicion

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Edward Snowden: NSA Whistle-Blower, ABDO Publishing Company, 2016. ProQuest Ebook Central,